anyone familiar with the literature of those times would broadly expect to hold generally true. The reality of Mauryan urban spaces, Taxila reveals, was far less regimented. Whatever the prescriptive vision, circumstances on the ground in those times, as mostly in contemporary urban India, were likely to be of greater significance in how the city and its streets were shaped.

In fact, the question in relation to Taxila that needs to be answered is this: if the city administrators had, as seems evident, undertaken a programme of public works and practically created a new communication network from scratch, why did they configure the streets to run in such an irregular way? The answer is unclear, but my guess, on the basis of what is known from below the streets and lanes, is that the city administration had to clear structures in the areas through which the roads were to be laid. Possibly, their clearance campaign was resisted by citizens whose lives were affected by the restructuring. It seems reasonable to think of some house owners, shopkeepers, and commercial proprietors willing to allow their properties to be acquired, and of others unwilling to allow their land and homes being cut for the sake of straight streets. The city planners at Taxila may have agreed in theory with Kautilya but found it prudent in practice to let the topography of subsidiary streets and lanes be determined by the availability of land rather than by a drawing board gridiron. The streets that resulted from this compromise are winding and haphazard, but they do seem to represent a citizen-friendly solution.

Realizing that the streets were inconveniently aligned for the pack animals that used them for the transport of goods, the planners took some care to ensure that the corners of houses in the streets were protected. This was done by constructing wheel-guards in the shape of stone pillars set up in corners. The pillars usually rose only a little less than a metre above the ground, with another half metre buried below ground. Also, even though the streets and lanes were usually narrow, there were substantial open